

Reflections from *The Literacy Review* Tutorial, Fall 2025

December 29, 2025

Each week in our tutorial, we would read a bunch of great works about adult education, literacy, community organizations, NYC, writing in English, learning English, hating English, design, and beyond. I had an amazing time writing my reflections and sharing them with my fellow editors, so this serves as a collection of the 8 or 9 writing responses to document them. Before we actually began the work as editors, we delved into the traditions, politics, and histories of our work—understanding the foundations of writing, literacy, education, editing, and publishing as tools of resistance and survival. I think the biggest thing I learned was the practice of editing as *care*. You will hear more about this in my final reflection. I hope you enjoy reading these (if anyone actually does) and I couldn't be more excited to work on, edit, create, and publish *The Literacy Review*'s 24th volume this upcoming Spring. I also can't wait to publish it here on my digital world!

Reflection #1: September 12, 2025

While I have always been struck by *The Literacy Review*'s breadth of works, I was very enamored by LR23 as I read the journal at a bench in Tompkins Square Park. I was impressed, excited, and even a little intimidated—it's a little daunting holding such a strong publication in your hands and knowing you're a part of the team that will be responsible for LR's next issue. LR23 set such a high standard. Yet reading it in full (alongside last year's prompts and Report on LR23) also helped spark many ideas in my brain on how we can continue the excellence of LR while taking new creative risks and liberties.

Something I think the workshops can encourage is playing with form and style. Very few pieces utilized this—it makes me wonder if students are taught how to experiment with form or if they're scared to do so. I personally find it both liberating and intimidating when professors encourage creative and unique forms of writing. It's difficult to break away from the traditional styles we're taught and told are the "right" way to write, and it's easy to practice the familiar. I think form experimentation provides a great learning opportunity for students and can open new creative horizons for many. I did notice that the call for submissions emphasizes this. However, I am hoping that Corinne and I's workshop can hopefully inspire more teachers to encourage their students to explore unconventional forms of writing.

Something else that I really enjoyed in the publication—and would love to see more of—is fiction writing. "Sam," by Jesus Arus Navarro, stood out to me because of its creativity and vivid description. I think the prompts could expand to include ones that

promote fiction pieces, since most of them are ones which invite students to reflect on their lives and tell personal stories. However, it's important to also note how this is one of the most important parts of *The Literacy Review*—it allows students who may not have had the chance to share their voices to be celebrated and published. Something I also found really enriching in the pieces were ones that drew on historical/political experiences (ADD). This directly relates to the introduction of the publication, which I thought was very relevant to the times and great at setting a framework for LR23.

Overall, I had a very enjoyable time reading LR23 and have many ideas for different prompts to ask students. I made a list of my favorite stories from LR23 and many of them came from the more personal subgenres, such as loss, love, and belonging. They were all so heartwarming and touching, so I think an added level of creativity through form experimentation could be a very positive experience for writers and highlight of L24. The exercise we did in class (picking a prompt and writing for 5 minutes) was very helpful (and fun!) to understand the importance of a prompt and figuring out how to find ones that are freeing, thought provoking, and meaningful to share.

Prompt ideas:

- When did you first feel like a New Yorker?
- Write about any rituals, traditions, or routines that you practice - whether they're familial, cultural, or religious traditions
- Narrative versus poem versus experimental/unique form

- Who gave you your name? What is the meaning of your name?
- What do you miss most about home?
- Write a story about someone who you saw one time
- What advice would you give your past self? What's the best piece of advice you have received? What could you learn from your past self?
- What was your childhood neighborhood like?
- What do you want to pass onto future generations—whether it's a tradition, an object, a piece of advice, a family heirloom, a secret
- What could you learn from your past self

Reflection #2 & Notes on NYPL ESOL and Immigrant Services: September 22, 2025

When I took Dianne Ramdeholl's class on Adult Literacy, we discussed how intertwined the student movement and adult literacy are, especially in this city, so getting a more in-depth history from "The Power of Student Writing and Action" was very interesting. Adult education is central to social change. I believe it is important to understand the broader history of student activism when we think about *The Literacy Review* as a publication that seeks to resist traditional notions of education. Placing it in conversation with the ongoing student movement and student intifada is especially important. I appreciated learning about the history of the Morales-Shakur Community Center and how students reestablished it in 2024 during the rise of the ongoing student movement (as discussed in "Alumni Divest from CUNY's complicity, invest in Palestinian liberation").

The way that education and literacy was understood by many of the central figures of Harlem University and CUNY student organizers/thinkers is reimaged today. This learning is community-centered and reflects ideas of revolution and liberation—ones that are found today through the encampments, student occupations of university buildings, in community libraries and places where principles of education are based on care and showing up for each other. They are also based on the philosophies of untraditional and accessible learning, which manifests itself in *The Literacy Review*. One of the quotes I loved the most from *New York Liberation School* was on page 124: "If we stretch our ideas of what it means to study—insisting that learning takes place both inside and outside of formal institutions, and that we remain students even when composing outside

of these institutions—then the basis for student power is much broader than we might otherwise measure.” This quote reminds me of the responsibilities we have as editors of *The Literacy Review*—which should be seen as a site of resistance similar to the publications discussed in *New York Liberation School*. Our work with *The Literacy Review* must be rooted in the liberatory education that student activists in NYC have demanded for decades.

Notes on NYPL ESOL and Immigrant Services

- **History**

- <https://privatelivespublicliteracies.wordpress.com/>
- Just a few decades after its opening in the 1890s, NYPL began offering services such as literacy programs, English language classes, and special collections that contained books in languages other than English
 - In 1910, the library created a foreign-language collection of 100,000 books in 25 different languages
(<https://www.nypl.org/blog/2010/04/14/trailblazer-immigrant-services-nypl>)
- Other resources beyond ESOL classes for adults include:
 - Citizenship classes
 - Computer classes in languages other than English
 - Cultural workshops and performances
 - Programming for immigrant children/children of immigrants
 - Multilingual Resources & World Languages Collections
 - Pasculano Learning Center (hub for adult learning w/ESOL, career services, etc. at NYPL Stavros Niarchos Foundation Library)
 - New Americans Corners (dedicated spaces that detail immigration/ESOL/adult literacy resources at each of the 92 locations across Manhattan/Bronx/Staten Island)
 - Both the NYPL website and Immigrant Services are able to be translated into many different languages
- In January 2006, NYPL opened the Latino and Puerto Rican Cultural Center at the Bronx Library center

- While it is not documented when Immigrant Services opened, the NYPL archives shows NYPL's commitment to accessible learning for all members of the greater community—this echoes the philosophy of NYPL (seen below)

- ***Mission***

- “The mission of The New York Public Library is to inspire lifelong learning, advance knowledge, and strengthen our communities.” To uphold this mission, the library aims to:
 - Inspire lifelong learning
 - Advance global knowledge
 - Provide free and open access materials/information
 - Strengthen communities through promoting full citizenship and participation in society

- ***Populations***

- While NYPL does not officially disclose exact numbers of student enrollment, I found that between 2019 and 2023, NYPL offered 90,000 ESOL spots and 11,000 spots for citizenship classes (<https://www.nyccaliteracy.org/index.html>)
- NYPL serves 3 boroughs: Manhattan, The Bronx, and Staten Island
- Communities / targeted services include:
 - Immigrant communities (ESOL/citizenship classes)
 - Low-income families (access to tech/wifi, after-school programs, job search assistance, tax help)
 - Adult literacy programs (ABE, job readiness, computer literacy, resume help)
 - Teens and YA (media literacy, events, college readiness programs)
 - Programs for children
 - Formerly incarcerated individuals (reentry programs, prison library partnerships)
 - Senior citizens
 - Queer and/or communities of color (special collections and monthly programs)

- ***Pedagogical approach***

- Learner-centered approach that is usually tailored to the needs of students
- Over 93,000 programs/classes annually, so a wide variety of practical, creative, academic, and other types of lessons
- ESOL classes at NYPL focus on Communicative Language Teaching (CLT)

- Emphasis on spoken communication rather than grammar
 - ESOL classes are usually weekly commitments over a period of time
- Classes integrate life skills curriculum (financial literacy, digital skills, health literacy, civic engagement), otherwise known as functional literacy
- Programs also encourage creative projects and creative thinking
- Many programs are volunteer-led
- Depending on the program, some instruction is one-on-one with an educator, but there are also both medium-sized and smaller group lessons
- After 2020, NYPL has expanded adult education to virtual and hybrid models
 - More of an emphasis on digital literacy/database learning (how to use online tools that the NYPL offers)
 - Emphasis on flexibility in learning
- Formative assessment approach
- ***Additional program for outreach***
 - <https://youthjustice.org/services> Youth Justice Network provides services to young adults who have been affected by the carceral system. In their education program, students attend classes as an alternative to incarceration.

Reflection #3: October 5, 2025

I was introduced to the banking concept of education in Professor Dianne Ramdeholl's writing seminar, Race, Social Justice, and Adult Literacy. It is obviously an important text thinking about education in a broader sense, but I think it is so critical to examine in the context of adult literacy. I think Freire's vision of problem-posing education is very present in many of the adult literacy spaces I have learned about/become familiar with (through both this class and others). More specifically, I think the recent workshops were a great example of how many educators rejected the banking model in their teaching-styles. The learning was participatory and inviting, which created an environment for everyone, including the workshop leader, to contribute equally. I really liked how Freire describes his ideas of liberation in education. For example:

“Education as the practice of freedom—as opposed to education as the practice of domination—denies that man is abstract, isolated, independent, and unattached to the world; it also denies that the world exists as a reality apart from people.”

The interconnectedness that Freire emphasizes is so relevant to understanding adult literacy programs where learning must be centered on lived experience in relation to political, historical, and social contexts. Here, knowledge is not replicated or deposited but rather co-created through dialogue between learners and educators. I also really love the language that Freire uses in his writing. For instance, when he describes the concept of “authenticity,” he ties it to the act of truly engaging with the world and others in a way that is honest and grounded in a desire for mutual liberation. It is very powerful and also

important to understand beyond a theoretical concept but also in practice through building trust and shared commitment.

In terms of my own educational experiences, I think an interdisciplinary approach to learning, like at Gallatin, very much rejects the banking model. I seek knowledge that is rooted in critical thinking and helps me understand its role in the world we live in. I am not just receiving or memorizing information, but rather actively engaging and exchanging knowledge with both my professors and fellow students. No one power or perspective dominates the learning process, and I am learning in an environment where oppression is challenged and social equality is reimagined. Through an emphasis on dialogue and authenticity, my education does serve as a practice of freedom. While Freire did not touch much on this in this specific excerpt we read, his ideas of education as an act of love resonated with me (this is also really emphasized in bell hooks' *Teaching to Transgress*). I think it is very important in the context of both adult literacy, our publication, and interdisciplinary education:

“Only by abolishing the situation of oppression is it possible to restore the love which that situation made impossible. If I do not love the world—if I do not love life—if I do not love people—I cannot enter into dialogue.”

Love in adult literacy represents commitment, care, building trust, and many other values critical to upholding the problem-posing model of education.

Reflection #4: 10/19/25

Reading James Baldwin's "If Black English Isn't a Language, Then Tell Me, What Is?" and Amy Tan's "Mother Tongue" in tandem made me think a lot more in depth about the power dynamics of English in *The Literacy Review*. Both writers examine how their own Black English and immigrant English, respectively, are not seen as legitimate by American society. In exploring the politics of English from two different perspectives, they also uncover the real-life effects of deeming a dialect or form of English as "broken" or "limited" as Tan explicitly criticizes. Baldwin expands on this point, emphasizing how Black English, in particular, was born out of necessity and survival, reflecting how its roots are directly connected to America's brutal history of slavery and oppression. Neglecting Black English dismisses the reality of Black experience in America, as Baldwin puts it.

Both Baldwin and Tan argue that language should be understood to reflect lived experiences rather than be upheld by standards which exclude and marginalize. They both connect this to education systems, where Baldwin explains the erasure of Black identities in schools while Tan shows how her experiences with English in school limited her perception of her intelligence and capabilities. They are both striking examples of Freire's banking system: in both of these cases, the oppressor, being the white, American dominant culture, imposes its language onto the oppressed, reinforcing the power imbalances which Freire discusses.

I think that these ideas are all very important to understanding the role of English in *The Literacy Review*. One particular example is when Tan explains how she uses

multiple Englishes in her writing in order to make it accessible to people like her mother, who she is writing about. I am wondering how we can further LR's role in maintaining accessibility in order to represent the people and voices who make up LR. How do we honor all types of Englishes in *The Literacy Review*? I think this will be a really interesting and important experience that we will probably encounter when selecting and editing works. After all, adult education and ESOL are inherently non-traditional, as are the Englishes that Baldwin and Tan describe. *The Literacy Review* therefore has the responsibility to challenge these linguistic and cultural limitations imposed by the dominant culture, and I hope that this year's writers will feel empowered and reclaim space like Baldwin and Tan do.

Reflection #5: 10/26/25

Notes on LR Volumes:

→ Volume 21:

- ◆ Layout feels simple but with very abstract and detailed drawings
 - In that way it feels like it draws on less than a specific theme and more of a color/design scheme
- ◆ I am not particularly a fan of the drawings inside (though I do really appreciate the cover and the boldness of the colors), because it feels like it puts more focus on the drawings rather than the stories itself
 - EX: the size of the page number is larger than the the title and it feels like the title and author names aren't as in focus

→ Volume 19:

- ◆ I like this design more more just because the design is very bold and relies a lot on typography which I think is cool; I wish it could include more illustrations to have a mix of typography and and illustration
- ◆ Volume 19 feels very dynamic and moving which is something I do love, but I think the way the elements come together in Volume 22 (in a more simple way) is also really beautiful compositionally—I think the balance between typography, color, and illustration should be playful
- I really do love Volumes 23 and 22 for that reason, especially because the covers themselves feel very bold and unique
- Many of the works seem to have similar section names
 - ◆ In 23, I do love how the illustrations correspond with the section themes
 - ◆ I like how detailed the section themes are in Volume 21

Diagrammatic Writing Notes:

- The positionality determines the three dimensionality of the flat space
 - ◆ In this case thinking about the LR book as the flat space
- I think that symmetry, harmony and entanglement are interesting ideas to work with and play around with in LR and visually they complicate the text while also in a way can be shaped to be accessible
- I love this reading for the way it uses its own formatting to comment on formatting and really plays with these dynamics, it makes the text so engaging and fun to read
- Though the text is simple, the format makes it a bit more challenging which is definitely fun to work with and think about in terms of LR
 - ◆ it reminds me of the design and typography of Volume 19

→ I am wondering if there are any ways we can play with text of actual pieces or formatting of them?

◆ Which position the title is in, border of author photo are some ideas I had

Reflection #6: November 3, 2025

I loved reading Gloria Anzaldúa's piece and the structure of the letter: it felt very intimate yet powerful, poetic, and collective. The form resists traditional notions of what "good writing" is, and she makes that very clear as she denounces what she describes as "the esoteric bullshit and pseudo-intellectualizing" that is taught and enforced in schools. Opening up with that sense of bluntness sets the tone for the rest of the letter, which strengthens her argument for understanding language as a tool for liberation—one that is both very personal and political, where both these dimensions intertwine and connect. I really enjoyed how Anzaldúa included her process of writing, where she very relatably describes second-guessing her work, starting over countless times, and her routine of postponing the act of writing itself. Yet, she also explains how writing and language empowers her. I admire her use of blending English with Spanish, the references to other women writers of color (I learned of so many excellent writers and poets!), and the direct tone used when confronting the standards that try to silence women of color and queer women of color.

Both Anzaldúa and Orwell critique the English language, but it comes across in many different ways. Anzaldúa rejects the ways English is imposed as a rigid source of conformity and instead reclaims it. She embraces the power of language, not just the power of English, as a space for freedom and expression. While Orwell likewise views language as inherently political, he, on the other hand, focuses on clarity of English, cautioning that careless language can be used to manipulate and control. The different structures between the two pieces is pretty extreme: Orwell, who is obviously writing in a

different time and context, writes in warnings and rules, versus Anzaldúa is experimental, blending the form of the letter, reflection, and criticism.

This particular piece from Orwell doesn't feel as relatable, inspiring, or as striking to me as Anzaldúa's, but I still think there's a lot of value in understanding both works especially when thinking about *The Literacy Review*. The expressiveness and rawness of "Speaking In Tongues" seems like it could be a good guide for writers in encouraging them to write freely and authentically. Like I said earlier, I appreciate the way Anzaldúa writes between Spanish and English and I think this can be inspiring for ESOL students. Orwell also makes a really good point when he describes the importance of simple and understandable language. Not only is this critical in order to avoid distortion and manipulation, which he adamantly warns readers about, but it also seems helpful for adult literacy learners when we think about accessibility. I think it's super important and can help LR contributors feel like writing and publishing writing is approachable—possibly helping give writers a sense of clarity? Obviously, I am not an adult literacy student, and I do not want to speak on their behalf, but I can see how emphasizing clear, honest, and expressive writing could feel empowering—or even radical—to contributors. On the other side of things, as an editor for *The Literacy Review*, both Anzaldúa and Orwell's pieces provide important lessons about expression, accessibility, and clarity, which I will definitely try to keep in mind when going through the editing process.

Reflection #7: November 13, 2025

I remember when the debate of whether or not we should capitalize the ‘B’ in Black became a major headline among the new wave of the anti-racist BLM movement and protests during 2020. Adopting the capital “B” quickly became a widespread decision, and most of the media I consumed implemented its use. The choice represents a way to reconcile with the brutal legacies of slavery and the racism still present in our society as well as a way to recognize the racial and political implications of linguistics. However, I also do believe that this overall change also had to do with the fact that many people (and institutions) were looking for public ways to respond to the movement.

I see the value in both sides of the argument, but the AP Style Blog announcements reminded me of the sort-of performativeness and how gestures like this can feel more symbolic than genuine. I understand that the blog posts were short briefs, intended to announce a style decision, but I think they leave a really important part of this debate out: the importance of race as a social construct. Minna Salami’s op-ed does point this out, and I think it is one of the most striking things in this debate—it shows how race only has meaning in the first place because of the way it was artificially assigned through language. The debate itself proves how racial labels are constructed as they are easily contested and inconsistent, which is definitely a hard thing to standardize across publications. The questions that come up for me are how can we understand the tension between a strict style guide for clarity and the socially constructed, fluid nature of race? In the context of LR’s style guide (specifically in the “ETHNIC AND RELIGIOUS

DESIGNATIONS” section) uses the AP’s standardization of Black and white while also explicitly honoring an author’s self-identification.

I think Salami’s article just stands out much more to me than the AP’s—her perspective seems more valuable—but especially when she points out that these conventions are imposed on her writing, even though she does not agree with it personally. She says, “It should not be in the hands of institutions and their guidelines to dictate what is best for black people at large: it is the individual author who should make their choice.” I think this is the best thing that I took away from these articles and even where the LR style guide says not to change how an author identifies. If the whole purpose of using a capital ‘B’ is to honor the “essential and shared sense of history, identity and community among people who identify as Black, including those in the African diaspora and within Africa,” as the AP announcement puts it, then shouldn’t we listen to individuals in those communities and what they want to identify as?

Reading these articles and thinking about racial constructs just makes me think about how hard it is to create a style guide, especially when these decisions hold a lot of weight and power. Obviously no one style or rule can fully capture the complexities of identity or the histories that these terms carry. But, I think it is important to hold nuance and autonomy when we think about these things. Style guides exist for the sake of clarity and consistency yet they shouldn’t override the voices and preferences of the communities they describe. I am curious about how LR came to its decision and if any writers have given their opinion.

Reflection #8: November 30, 2025

Fargo Tbakhi's "Notes on Craft: Writing in the Hour of Genocide" and his criticisms of language remind me so much of Gloria Anzaldúa's "Speaking in Tongues." Both Tbakhi and Anzaldúa denounce what writing—specifically, English writing—should look, sound, or be. As soon as I began to read the article, I immediately thought of a concept very similar to Audre Lorde's "the master's tools cannot dismantle the master's house." Arabic as a language is the root of Arab culture, so many Arab writers are criticized for writing in Western languages. I grew up hearing arguments similar to Lorde's, where "the colonizer's tongue" was always seen as a threat to the cultural pride and richness of Arabic. I notice many activists who criticize non-Arabic speaking Arabs when speaking about Palestine or liberation. I think these ideas are really interesting when considering Tbakhi's work since he suggests a different approach that uses these tensions as a space for what he calls an "Alternative Craft." While Tbakhi doesn't mention the Arabic language specifically, his ideas are inherently relevant to Arabic: he translates Arab writers while condemning Craft. As he points out, Craft is reductionary as it is based on imperial systems and "contingent upon ethical and political failure." I see Arabic, the mother tongue for many of the creatives he mentions, as the opposite: linguistically, Arabic inherently is a fluid and idiomatic language. Arabic translation (into English) is often seen as reductive, with many pointing out that English cannot capture Arabic. I think Tbakhi's notion of the Craft does a great job explaining why, through, for example, the oversimplistic and fragmented "Craft decisions" which he mentions.

Tbakhi also describes how (the English) language legitimizes violence, specifically in its "categories of 'terrorist' and 'terrorism.'" I think this is such an important section in the article. America only views terrorists as a specific racial category, as a specification for those who are not white—hence why Tbakhi calls it a weapon of the state. I like how this section reclaims the word terrorism by stripping it of its authority, suggesting that “we” can embrace the term through “hijacking the interview” or “writing things that are unpublishable and forcing publishers into doing it anyway” or “loud, annoying, and resolutely steadfast in our refusals and our insistences.” This transitions well into his next point about writing as a space as a combat to Craft. I think Ghassan Kanafani is an excellent example to represent political thought to the antithesis of Craft because of his dual role as a revolutionary leader and esteemed poet. Yet, Tbakhi concludes by representing Craft as a lie, an illusion that disciplines writers “while the boot is on our neck or on somebody else’s.” Language is a form of survival, liberation, and resistance for Tbakhi, who vulnerably admits that he wrote “all this” in order to access parts of writing that Craft suppresses, especially in times of oppression and genocide. The abandonment of Craft represents the abandonment of the systems which stand in the way of liberation. Here, Tbakhi also situated himself within the line of Palestinian creators and writers whose creations and works are inseparable from political thought and liberation. Political writing is a refusal of empire, and Craft is a barrier to this refusal.

In so much of Arabic language writing and poetry, ideas like the homeland and freedom are often personified, and doing so here directly contrasts with the English restrictions of Craft. I really love this quote below:

“(And liberation moves too, it has its own sort of agency, it can dance a little, as you stare through the hole in the fence you’ve just cut you might feel a hand on your shoulder, someone standing by your side like a friend, liberation letting you know what it feels like, that you’re going the right way.)”

Resistance imagery is often tied to the homeland, and this reminds me of one of my favorite parts in Mahmoud Darwish’s *In the Presence of Absence*, where Darwish talks about cities as smells. I feel like the dynamism and free-formness of the text is what distinguishes Craft, flat and restrictive, from liberatory poetry that is fluid and takes on many forms. There is a sense of agency that is granted in the anti-Craft system of writing, and I think that is very much embodied in Arabic. Craft in its nature is a boundless system, while Fargo Tbakhi calls for a reassessment of the way we write—to break that system. He uses the phrase “there is no busienss as usual” that has been reproduced and repeated throughout the genocide. It’s mostly used as a call to disrupt the order of American or Western holidays and traditions, which are systems that reinforce Craft and the violence it sanctions. It is also important to note that in the case of the ongoing genocide (and throughout its history of settler colonialism against Palestinians), Israel has targeted attacks on holidays in order to distract the public from its violence. This cycle of violence is replicated through Craft.

Tbakhi also describes how (the English) language legitimizes violence, specifically in its "categories of 'terrorist' and 'terrorism.'" I think this is such an important section in the article. America only views terrorists as a specific racial category, as a specification for those who are not white—hence why Tbakhi calls it a weapon of the state. I like how this section reclaims the word terrorism by stripping it of its authority, suggesting that “we” can embrace the term through “hijacking the interview” or “writing things that are unpublishable and forcing publishers into doing it anyway” or “loud, annoying, and resolutely steadfast in our refusals and our insistences.” This transitions well into his next point about writing as a space as a combat to Craft. I think Ghassan Kanafani is an excellent example to represent political thought to the antithesis of Craft because of his dual role as a revolutionary leader and esteemed poet. Yet, Tbakhi concludes by representing Craft as a lie, an illusion that disciplines writers “while the boot is on our neck or on somebody else’s.” Language is a form of survival, liberation, and resistance for Tbakhi, who vulnerably admits that he wrote “all this” in order to access parts of writing that Craft suppresses, especially in times of oppression and genocide. The abandonment of Craft represents the abandonment of the systems which stand in the way of liberation. Here, Tbakhi also situated himself within the line of Palestinian creators and writers whose creations and works are inseparable from political thought and liberation. Political writing is a refusal of empire, and Craft is a barrier to this refusal. Overall, I really enjoyed this reading and thought it was super inspiring read—though it is saddening to read nearly two years into the genocide.

Final Reflection (#9): December 8, 2025

Unpacking *The Literacy Review* as a publication alongside enriching readings and experiences like the workshops has helped me learn so much more about adult education and liberatory pedagogy. I believe that the publication represents Freire's ideas of education as a "practice of freedom," and this semester, I have enjoyed learning how to bring these values into the act of editing. Since my freshman year, I've been so inspired and amazed by *The Literacy Review*. Being able to continue this project and its legacy is such an honor. I am so excited to delve into the deeper work of selecting, editing, and publishing a collection of voices from across NYC. I remember holding LR23 and thinking about how by the end of this year, we'll have helped produce another one!

The ways in which we've spent this semester preparing for the bulk of work next semester felt like such a warm introduction to such a special project. For example, I really enjoyed creating prompts for the writers and I can't wait to see how they may (or may not) interpret and respond to the questions we wrote back in the beginning of this process. The five-minute writing exercise we did (responding to prompts of LR23) felt so freeing and thought-provoking. I hope that the writers of LR24 feel that our prompts are meaningful and inspiring, but I'm also excited to see works that are entirely out of the box. Another fundamental experience was the October Workshops—seeing instructors both presenting and learning reminded me of the mutual respect and care that Freire strongly advocated for. They were in spaces that were participatory and inviting to all, just as Freire imagined when describing his problem-posing model of education. I also

just thought it was so impactful how the workshops were such a familiar event for many, one that a lot of people said they looked forward to each year.

Understanding Freire and liberatory education outside of the classroom, in our editing context, means upholding an author's agency and authentic voice and bringing clarity not as a way to standardize or conform a text, but rather as a way to uplift the piece. This is especially important in adult literacy, where the banking model of education must be actively rejected in a system that has historically failed many students. Therefore, the interconnectedness of learning between the editor, the writer, and the piece should be shared and grounded in mutual learning. As a copy-editor for *Confluence*, I had never thought about framing editing as a practice of freedom. After engaging with our assigned readings from this semester, I understand how learning in editing is very reciprocal: I am growing and changing alongside the piece just as the piece itself is growing and changing in the process.

I also really enjoyed reading James Baldwin's "If Black English Isn't a Language, Then Tell Me, What Is?" and Amy Tan's "Mother Tongue" together. These readings made me think very deeply about how we can honor the many types of Englishes in LR24. More specifically, how can we use editing—as a practice of freedom and a labor of love—to make LR24 a space where this wide variety of English is welcomed in its full authenticity rather than restricted to the dominant styles which Baldwin and Tan reject through their writing? I also think that Baldwin's explicit emphasis on language as inherently political and Tan's more subtle exploration of politicized language is such an important conversation to be thinking about when editing. Connecting this back to Freire,

who believes that we must read everything in the social and political context of the world, we should make space for writers to speak the languages that hold their truths and authentic voices.

This also reminds me of “The Power of Student Writing and Action” from *New York Liberation School*. Reading about activists like Shakur and Morales and their efforts to use the written and published word as a space for reclamation and resistance was inspiring in thinking about a publication like LR. I love this quote especially: “If we stretch our ideas of what it means to study—insisting that learning takes place both inside and outside of formal institutions, and that we remain students even when composing outside of these institutions—then the basis for student power is much broader than we might otherwise measure.” Editing as a practice and within *The Literacy Review* has to be placed outside the context of the formal institution and one that is instead measured by its capacity to empower and honor the voices of adult education and ESOL students—something that is inherently nontraditional and political.

I hope that this year’s writers will feel empowered and reclaim space for their voices, and I hope that writers who may have never had a chance to to be published will feel a sense of belonging. On our end, I’m so excited to see how we will develop our own styles in liberatory editing and honoring the writers’ voices. Though I have experience as an editorial board member, I imagine that selecting works out of 500 submissions rather than 50 will feel entirely different. I also think it will feel so different because of the informative readings we got to experience together. This semester has been so interesting and fun to meet our fellow editors and *The Literacy Review* as a whole. I can’t wait to

dive deeper into editing and learn about the process of publishing with the amazing readings we spent time with in the back of our minds. I'm also just looking forward to the collaborative process we will embark on together after a semester filled with insightful discussion, challenging (and fun!) editing quizzes, and getting to know my fellow editors. I'm feeling a lot of gratitude and there is still so much to do, to learn, and look forward to. Thank you so much for everything!